

NEED ASSESSMENT BRIEF

Compliance Case Management System (CCMS)

IPDU-SOP-001, Step 1 — Identify and Document the Need

SOP Reference	IPDU-SOP-001, Step 1 — Identify and Document the Need
System / Project	Compliance Case Management System (CCMS)
Requesting Unit	Compliance Unit, Office of the Public Service Commission
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Status	Draft — Submitted to Director IPDU for awareness and initial direction before Step 2

1. Purpose of This Brief

This Need Assessment Brief is prepared in accordance with Step 1 of IPDU-SOP-001 (Identifying, Developing and Implementing Digital Applications and Automated Systems, May 2026). It documents the identified operational need for a Compliance Case Management System (CCMS) within the Office of the Public Service Commission, and is submitted to the Director IPDU for awareness and initial direction before the process proceeds to Step 2 (Technology Assessment).

This brief is based on a review of six procedural documents supplied by the Compliance Unit, covering the full range of disciplinary, misconduct, suspension, and grievance workflows administered by the OPSC, and on the email exchange between the Compliance Unit and IPDU from May 2026. Volumes and as-is tooling details marked TBD require confirmation with the Compliance Unit before Step 3 commences.

2. Problem Statement

The Compliance Unit of the OPSC administers at least six distinct statutory compliance and disciplinary workflow families on behalf of the Public Service Commission. These workflows govern the full lifecycle of disciplinary matters, serious misconduct investigations, temporary suspensions, grievance mediations, and performance management processes for both employees and senior executives across the Vanuatu public service.

Each workflow carries statutory obligations — including mandatory time limits, defined notification steps, required forms, and Commission decision-making authority — with legal consequences for non-compliance. Despite this, the Compliance Unit currently manages all of these workflows through a combination of manual processes, physical files, and unstructured records. No purpose-built tracking or case management system exists.

This creates five compounding operational problems:

- **Deadline invisibility.** Statutory time limits — 21-day investigation windows, 5-day SMDR referral obligations, 45-day Commission confirmation deadlines, 3-calendar-day suspension response windows — are tracked manually or not tracked at all. There is no mechanism to alert officers when a deadline is approaching or has been missed.

- Case record fragmentation. Evidence, warnings, responses, suspension notices, investigation reports, and Commission decisions are held across physical files, email inboxes, and spreadsheets with no single authoritative case record. Retrieving a complete case history for Commission consideration or legal review is time-consuming and prone to gaps.
- Workflow inconsistency across case types. Six procedurally distinct workflow families — each with different stages, actors, time limits, and outcome types — are managed without a common framework. There is no system-level enforcement of the correct sequence for each case type.
- Audit trail gaps. Commission and PSDB decisions carry legal effect and may be subject to judicial review. Without an immutable record of who took what action at each stage and when, the OPSC is exposed to challenges that a digital system would foreclose.
- Litigation and cost exposure. The Compliance Unit specifically identified the need to track litigation matters and manage associated costs for closed cases. Without structured tracking, cost overruns and legal exposure cannot be monitored effectively.

3. Workflow Scope and System Actors

3.1 Case Families in Scope

The following six workflow families are in scope for the CCMS, as derived from the six procedural documents supplied by the Compliance Unit.

Case Family	Subject / Who	Key Statutory Deadlines	Decision Authority
Employee Internal Disciplinary	All public servants (non-senior)	Notice of Allegation: 5 working days to respond; MDC preliminary assessment: 1 week (5 working days); SMDR referral by DG: 5 working days; PSDB notice: ≥28 days; Commission confirmation of PSDB order: 45 days	PSDB + Commission confirmation
Serious Misconduct — Employee	All public servants (non-senior)	MDC assessment: 1 week; Investigation panel: 21 days; Panel report to Commission: 7 days after completion; Employee response to findings: 1 week	Commission
Temporary Suspension	Any public servant	SMDR issued to staff member: 3 calendar days from suspension; Staff response to OPSC: 3 calendar days; Maximum suspension period: 2 months (half salary)	Commission (notification required)
Grievance Process	Any staff member vs DG / Director / equivalent	Mediator appointed: within 5 calendar days of complaint; Mediation resolution: within 10	Mediator / Secretary OPSC

		working days of appointment	
Senior Executive — Serious Misconduct	DG, Director, Secretary General, Town Clerk, Auditor General, OPSC Secretary	Investigation: 21 days; Panel report: 7 days after completion; Subject response: 1 week; Commission decision: within 45 days of complaint (or 75 days if additional information requested)	Commission
Senior Executive — Poor Performance	DG, Director, Secretary General, Town Clerk, Auditor General, OPSC Secretary	Employee response to written warning: 1 week	Commission

3.2 System Actors

The following actors interact with the system at various stages across the six workflow families.

Actor / Role	Function in the Compliance Workflow
PSC / Commission	Ultimate decision-making authority across all case types; confirms or varies PSDB orders; removes senior executives; must act within 45-day confirmation window
Secretary OPSC	Manages senior-officer grievances and disciplinary offences below serious misconduct; receives SMDR referrals from DGs; notifies Commission of suspensions; may suspend staff if DG fails to act; appoints mediators
Director General (DG) / Director / Equivalent	First-level disciplinary authority for employees; issues warnings; refers to MDC; submits SMDR to OPSC within 5 working days of receiving employee response
Ministerial Disciplinary Committee (MDC)	Assesses grounds for serious misconduct; recommends suspension or internal resolution; preliminary assessment must be completed within 1 week (5 working days)
Public Service Disciplinary Board (PSDB)	Hears formal disciplinary matters referred by Commission; issues orders (warning, demotion, suspension without pay, compulsory retirement, dismissal); all orders subject to Commission confirmation within 45 days
OPSC Compliance Unit	Receives SMDR from DGs; assesses evidence; requests additional documents (within 5 working days); liaises with ministries; refers matters to Commission or PSDB; administers grievance mediation process
Investigative Panel	Appointed by Commission for serious misconduct matters (employee and senior executive); completes investigation within 21 days; submits report to Commission within 7 days of completion

Mediator (appointed per case)	Resolves grievance or conflict; must settle dispute within 10 working days of appointment; produces Memorandum of Mediation (PSC Form 6.8) signed by both parties
Staff Member / Subject	Respondent in all disciplinary and grievance cases; has defined response windows at each stage; entitled to representation at PSDB hearings; may support responses with documentary evidence

4. Named Forms and Artefacts for Digitisation

The procedural documents reference the following named forms and artefacts. Each must be accommodated in the system's document management and workflow design.

Form / Artefact	Used In	Role in the Digital System
PSC Form 6-1 — Staff Member Discipline Report (SMDR)	All employee disciplinary and suspension workflows	Primary intake artefact from DG to OPSC; anchors the case record; must attach warnings, responses, and supporting evidence
PSC Form 6-4 — Progressive Disciplinary Action Form	Employee internal disciplinary — counselling step	Records counselling and restorative behaviour; placed on staff member's personal file
PSC Form 6.8 — Memorandum of Mediation (MoM)	Grievance process — outcome step	Records mediation discussions and settlement; signed by both parties and mediator; submitted to Secretary OPSC
Notice of Allegation	Employee internal disciplinary	Must be issued before any formal warning; subject has 5 working days to respond
First Warning / Second Warning letters	Employee internal disciplinary	Issued by DG/Director; valid for 3 years from date of issue; must be attached to SMDR on referral to OPSC
Suspension Notice	Temporary suspension and serious misconduct	Triggers SMDR issuance within 3 calendar days; Commission notification required
Investigation Panel Report	Senior executive and employee serious misconduct	Submitted to Commission within 7 days of completion; released to subject employee for response before Commission decision
Commission Decision Notice	All cases reaching Commission level	Written notice to all parties; records decision and reasons; removal of DG/Director takes effect on date of decision

5. System Requirements Implied by the Procedural Documents

The following functional requirements are derived directly from the statutory procedures and the Compliance Unit's expressed requirements. This list constitutes the seed backlog for Step 3 (Concept Note and Requirements

Definition). It is not exhaustive — additional requirements will be identified through workflow validation sessions with the Compliance Unit.

#	Requirement	Source / Rationale
FR-01	Case registration: log a new case with case type, subject employee, initiating officer, ministry/department, date received, and initial document attachments	All six workflow families — every case begins with a logged intake record
FR-02	Case type routing: system presents the correct stage sequence based on the case family and subject type (employee vs senior executive) selected at registration	Six distinct workflow families with different stages, actors, SLAs, and outcomes
FR-03	SLA / deadline tracking: automatic date calculations for each statutory time limit per stage; colour-coded alerts when approaching or overdue	21-day investigation windows, 45-day confirmation, 5-day referral, 3-calendar-day suspension response — all statutory obligations with legal consequence
FR-04	Document attachment: upload and attach forms, evidence, warnings, and response letters at each stage; retained in version-controlled case record	SMDR must bundle all prior warnings, responses, and evidence; investigation report must be released to subject employee
FR-05	Role-based access control: OPSC Compliance officers, Secretary, Commission members, DG/Director (restricted read), and system admin — with permissions calibrated per role and stage	Multiple actors with different read and write rights at different stages across all workflow families
FR-06	Immutable audit trail: every status change, document upload, decision, and actor action logged with timestamp and cannot be altered retroactively	Statutory accountability and potential judicial review of Commission and PSDB decisions
FR-07	Case dashboard: live view of all open cases by type, stage, SLA status (on-track / at-risk / overdue), and assigned officer	Compliance Unit needs to manage caseload across all six families simultaneously
FR-08	Decision recording: structured capture of Commission / PSDB decision with outcome type (reinstate, terminate, warn, demote, etc.), date, and narrative; triggers downstream status update	Commission decisions carry legal effect; precision and traceability are mandatory
FR-09	Internal notification and reminders: automated alerts to assigned officers when action is required or deadline is approaching — internal to the system	Prevents silent deadline misses across multiple concurrent cases and officers

	in Phase 1, with email integration in a later phase	
FR-10	Reporting: case volumes by type and outcome; average time per stage; overdue cases by officer; caseload trends over time	Management oversight, Commission reporting cycle, and IPDU post-launch review requirements
FR-11	Grievance sub-module: track mediator appointment, mediation period, outcome (settled / not settled), and MoM attachment	Grievance process is structurally distinct — different actors, timeline, and outcome artefact from disciplinary workflows
FR-12	Senior executive flag: cases for DG, Director, Secretary General, Town Clerk, Auditor General, and OPSC Secretary must be flagged and routed through the Commission-level workflow — not the standard employee workflow	Separate statutory procedures apply to senior officers under the Public Service Act
FR-13	Litigation and cost tracking: ability to record and monitor litigation matters associated with cases, including costs for closed cases	Explicitly requested by Compliance Unit in initial proposal to IPDU; reduces cost overruns and improves legal exposure visibility
FR-14	AI readiness: system architecture must support future integration of AI-assisted features (case summarisation, classification, decision-support) without requiring core redesign	Both Compliance Unit and IPDU identified AI-readiness as a requirement; Django backend selected in part for this capability — Phase 3 only, with explicit Secretary endorsement before any AI feature is activated

6. Preliminary Technical Alignment

The Compliance Unit's initial proposal (May 2026 email exchange) specified a technology stack. IPDU has reviewed this against IPDU-SOP-001 Section 3 (Open Source by Default) and Annex A. The table below records the alignment and any IPDU adjustments, for transparency ahead of Step 2 (Technology Assessment Note).

Component	Compliance Unit Proposal	IPDU Technical Position
Backend	FastAPI (Python)	Django (Python). Django's ORM, admin layer, and security features are better suited to complex multi-stage workflow management and audit trail requirements than FastAPI. Django also supports AI integration without architectural redesign. Both are open-source Python frameworks.
Frontend	Angular	Angular. IPDU agrees. Angular provides a mature, structured framework well-suited to case management interfaces with complex role-based views.

Database	PostgreSQL	PostgreSQL. Full agreement. Robust, open source, and standard for government data persistence.
Deployment	Docker + Kubernetes	Docker containers on a DCDT-managed secure VM. Kubernetes introduces unnecessary complexity at current scale (~50–100 users). Can be revisited if scale significantly increases. VM environment provisioned and managed by DCDT.
UI/UX Design	Figma — validated before development	Figma. Full agreement. UI/UX design and stakeholder validation in Figma before any development begins is an IPDU requirement.
AI integration	AI-readiness as a design principle	Confirmed as Phase 3 only. Django architecture supports this. Requires explicit Secretary endorsement before Phase 3 development commences, per IPDU-SOP-001 Section 5 Step 3.
Security	Strong security measures	Role-based access control, immutable audit log, HTTPS/TLS, and segregation of duties are core design requirements. DCDT to advise on server hardening and backup configuration.
Hosting	Not specified	On-premise DCDT-managed infrastructure within Vanuatu. No offshore hosting of PSC compliance data. Aligns with Annex A sovereignty requirement.

Note: The full Technology Assessment Note (Gate 1) will be prepared at Step 2 and submitted to the Director IPDU for approval before Step 3 commences. The preliminary alignment above is for information only and does not constitute Gate 1 approval.

6.1 API Integration with the Commission Decision App

CCMS will communicate with the Commission Decision App via internal REST API. Both systems will be built on the same Django/PostgreSQL stack and deployed on the same DCDT-managed server, making the integration a server-internal API call with no external network dependency.

The integration avoids double data entry: a disciplinary form submission (PSC Forms 6.x) logged in the Commission Decision App automatically notifies CCMS, which creates a linked compliance case record. Neither system needs to re-enter what the other already holds. The following data flows are anticipated:

- Commission Decision App → CCMS: when a discipline form (PSC 6.x) is registered in the tracker, CCMS is notified and opens a linked compliance case record, pre-populated with the submission reference, form type, originating ministry, and date received.
- CCMS → Commission Decision App: when a Commission decision on a disciplinary matter is recorded in CCMS, the corresponding submission record in the tracker is updated with the outcome.

- CCMS → Commission Decision App (limited): the tracker can display a high-level status indicator (e.g. “Active compliance case”) against a discipline submission, giving PSC Officers visibility without exposing sensitive case detail to ministry users.

A critical design constraint governs this integration: CCMS case detail — investigation findings, suspension records, subject responses, disciplinary history, grievance outcomes, and PSDB orders — must never be exposed to ministry-side users through the Commission Decision App. The API boundary must enforce this explicitly. The exact data boundary rules and integration scope will be defined as a named design constraint in the CCMS Concept Note at Step 3.

7. Current State (As-Is) — TBD

The as-is workflow detail — including specific manual tools currently in use (spreadsheets, Outlook folders, paper files), approximate case volumes, urgency classifications, and known pain points beyond those documented in the procedural documents — has not yet been gathered. This information is required before Step 3 commences.

The following will be confirmed through the discovery meeting with the Compliance Unit:

- Approximate annual case volumes by case family
- Current tools used to track each workflow family (spreadsheet, shared drive, physical file, Outlook, or other)
- Current pain points not already captured in this brief
- Approximate number of system users and their ministry/department locations
- Existing data that may need to be migrated into the system at go-live
- Preferred phasing priorities — which workflow families should be built first

8. Preliminary View on the Appropriate Solution

Based on the procedural documents and email exchange reviewed, the appropriate solution is a purpose-built, government-owned web application for compliance case management — not an adaptation of a generic commercial case management or CRM platform.

The statutory specificity of the workflows, the sensitivity of the data (disciplinary records, Commission decisions, suspension histories, grievance outcomes), and the sovereignty requirement that government HR and compliance data remain within Vanuatu together place this system firmly in the category of government-specific operational systems under Annex A (April 2026). That category requires open-source, build-from-scratch development on DCDT-managed infrastructure.

The system is not a replacement for HRMIS. It is a purpose-built compliance and disciplinary case management platform designed for the Compliance Unit's specific statutory workflows. Any future integration with HRMIS will be scoped as a later-phase enhancement.

9. Next Steps

Subject to Director IPDU's awareness and initial direction on this brief, IPDU proposes the following next steps:

- Director IPDU reviews this brief and provides initial direction.
- IPDU proceeds to Step 2: prepare the Technology Assessment Note confirming the open-source-by-default approach and submit for Gate 1 approval.
- Following Gate 1 approval, IPDU conducts workflow validation sessions with the Compliance Unit to confirm as-is detail, volumes, and phasing priorities (filling all TBD items in this brief).
- IPDU prepares the Concept Note and circulates to Director IPDU and OPSC Management for review, leading to Secretary endorsement before any development commences (Step 3).

- IPDU initiates parallel discussions with DCDT on server provisioning and hosting environment.

Authorisation

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